Argumentative Indian

Zia Mody, *67*
Co-founder & Managing Partner, AZB & Partners

ACCOMPLISHMENT
One of India's top legal eagles with unmatched skills in acquisitions, joint ventures, company restructuring and corporate law

WHILE SHE WAS YOUNG, Zia was excited to see her father, the legendary former attorney general of India Soli Sorabjee, practise law. Although Sorabjee would be in court all day, he would never miss the family dinner. It was then that she would listen to all the talk that Sorabjee would do regarding the various cases he handled. "It was always frenetic, energetic, argumentative... having to win every time, fighting everything as a war, never a skirmish. And, given that I also have quite an argumentative nature, it appealed immediately," she said in an earlier interview. Drawn into the same profession, she worked in the US for five years at Baker & McKenzie. However, she came back to India "essentially to get married (to childhood sweetheart Jaydev Mody, currently, the chairman of Delta Corp) and (then I) stepped into another world altogether." The couple have three daughters—well-known furniture designer Anjali, Aditi and Aarti.

Zia's professional beginnings were very humble. In her office in Mumbai, she had a small desk which she shared with her senior lawyer, and they had no secretary. She could not practise with her father, as he would be mostly in Delhi. However, he advised her: "Don't forget that the ultimate person you are arguing before is a judge, and that you are always an officer of the court; that your client is important, but never more important than your reputation with the judge." Therefore, there was always an effort from her to do the right thing in court. According to Zia, one's sense of self-worth and confidence, and the ability to sleep at night about what one did during the day is more important than winning that fight through the wrong means.

It was not easy for a woman to break into what was essentially a male bastion. As a young barrister, she would work 30 per cent more than her male counterpart—aware that she would be the only woman arguing the case that day. All her hard work has paid off. It is often said in legal and corporate circles that few of Zia's peers can match her skills when it comes to acquisitions, joint ventures, company restructuring, foreign inward investment-related practice and corporate law. ■

–M.G. Arun

THE LAW OF ETHICS

"I've always grown up to acknowledge clients as important, but not vitally necessary to my existence if they cross my moral compass"



OFF COURT Has a passion for thoroughbreds at Mumbai's Mahalaxmi Racecourse and used to ride them in her younger days

MILIND SHELTE